

Mumbai Heritage Guide

BOM001: Gateway of India. The Gateway of India is an iconic arch monument built during the 20th century in Bombay. It was erected to commemorate the landing of King George V and Queen Mary at Apollo Bunder on their visit to India in 1911. Designed by Scottish architect George Wittet, the structure is built in the Indo-Saracenic style, blending Roman triumphal arch architecture with local Gujarati designs. It is constructed from yellow basalt and reinforced concrete. Ironically, the monument built to welcome British monarchs was also the exact departure point for the last British troops leaving India in 1948.

BOM002: Elephanta Caves. Located on Elephanta Island in Mumbai Harbour, this UNESCO World Heritage Site is a collection of cave temples predominantly dedicated to the Hindu god Shiva. The rock-cut architecture dates back to the 5th and 6th centuries. The main cave (Cave 1) is famous for its massive, 20-foot-tall Trimurti sculpture, which depicts a three-headed Shiva representing the creator, preserver, and destroyer of the universe. The island was named 'Elephanta' by 16th-century Portuguese explorers who found a colossal stone elephant near the entrance. The intricate carvings represent a masterpiece of ancient Indian rock-cut art and religious devotion.

BOM003: Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Terminus. Formerly known as Victoria Terminus, this historic railway station is a UNESCO World Heritage Site and the headquarters of the Central Railway in India. Designed by British architect F. W. Stevens in an exuberant Italian Gothic style, it was completed in 1888 to commemorate Queen Victoria's Golden Jubilee. The building brilliantly blends Victorian Gothic Revival architecture with traditional Indian palace elements, featuring stone domes, turrets, pointed arches, and eccentric ground plans. It remains one of the busiest railway stations in India, serving over three million commuters daily and standing as a symbol of Mumbai's mercantile spirit.

BOM004: Haji Ali Dargah. Floating in the Arabian Sea, the Haji Ali Dargah is a renowned mosque

and tomb located on an islet off the coast of Worli, Mumbai. Built in 1431 in memory of a wealthy Muslim merchant, Sayyed Peer Haji Ali Shah Bukhari, who gave up all his worldly possessions before making a pilgrimage to Mecca. The whitewashed structure is connected to the mainland by a narrow 500-yard causeway that is completely submerged during high tide, making it accessible only during low tide. The complex exemplifies beautiful Indo-Islamic architecture and attracts people of all faiths seeking blessings.

BOM005: Siddhivinayak Temple. The Shree Siddhivinayak Ganapati Mandir is one of the richest and most prominent Hindu temples in Mumbai, dedicated to Lord Ganesha. Originally built in 1801 by Laxman Vithu and Deubai Patil, the temple houses a unique idol of Ganesha carved out of a single black stone, with the deity's trunk tilted to the right. The inner roof of the sanctum is plated with gold. Over the years, it has transformed from a small shrine into a massive five-story structure. It is heavily frequented by politicians, Bollywood stars, and millions of devotees seeking prosperity and success.